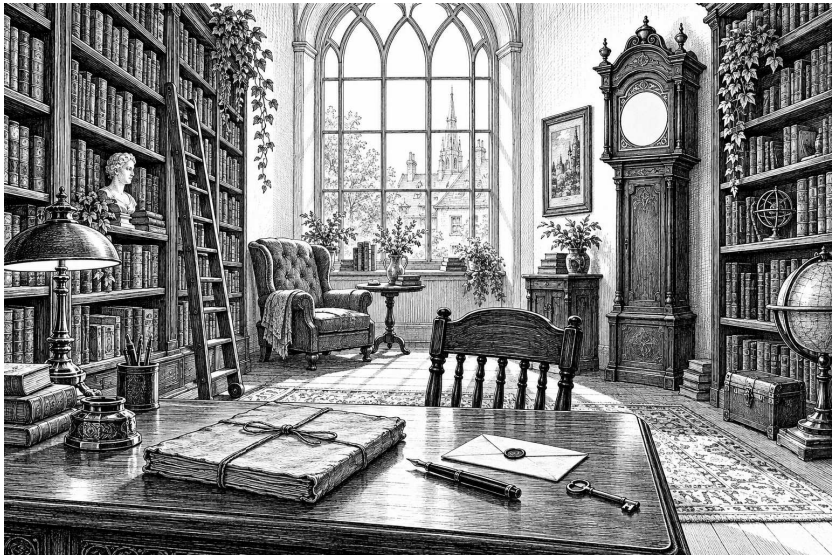
The Lost Manuscript

Six connected literary mysteries



READING INSTRUCTIONS

How to follow the paper trail

What you need

A pencil and this book. A separate sheet is optional. Play alone or share the documents with another reader. No internet, outside research or specialist knowledge is required.

The six cases

Read each opening, inspect its four documents, and record the route on its recovery certificate. Every case supplies its own evidence. The four discoveries connect in the order shown in the file inventory.

Hints without haste

Optional hints begin on page 73. Each puzzle has three increasingly direct nudges. Read one, return to the document, and wait before taking the next.

Checking your work

The sealed explanations begin on page 85. Find your case there to confirm the route and read its discovery. They reveal answers; keep those pages closed while playing.

The recovered story

Each case includes a manuscript fragment marked “Read after solving”. Collect the fragments in case order. Together they tell Mara’s journey through a city whose library lends hours.

THE ARCHIVE INDEX

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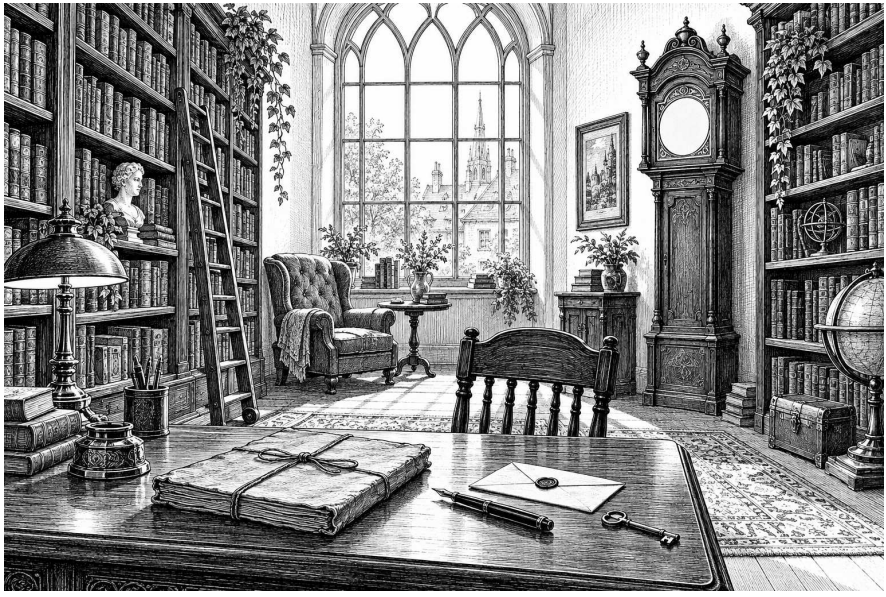
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CASE I

The Keeper’s Letter



Bellwether Books

A gathering waits beyond the papers.

THE STORY

The next room

By late afternoon, Bellwether Books will be full of people. The lamps are ready, the dust is gone, and the old reading room is opening for the first time in years. Ada Bell, the new keeper, has asked you to help with one last thing.

‘Elsie left this for whoever would listen,’ she says, sliding an envelope across the counter. Elsie Rowan retired last winter, after forty years of knowing which book every customer needed. She has sent a note instead of attending tonight’s opening.

For decades, the shop’s inventory has carried a curious entry: *A Map of Unwritten Hours*, an unpublished manuscript by its founder, Elias Rowan. Nobody has seen the pages. Nobody knows whether the book was ever finished.

Inside Elsie’s envelope are a five-line letter and three old records. Her instruction is brief: ‘Find the first folio. A direction leads to a shelf; the middle book leads to an object. My work log will tell you how to open what you find.’

DOCUMENT I

Elsie’s envelope

The note has five carefully spaced lines. Above them, Elsie wrote: “Begin well, and you will know where to look.”

BELLWETHER BOOKS

No story is lost while someone keeps looking.

Old shelves have longer memories than we do.

Read the room before you read its books.

There is a beginning hidden in every line.

Hold on to the direction when you find it.

Elsie Rowan

The reading room has four shelves: NORTH, EAST, SOUTH and WEST. Take your direction to the shelf record.

My discovery:

DOCUMENT II

The shelf record

On the named shelf, five books stand in one straight row. Reconstruct their positions from left to right, with no gaps.

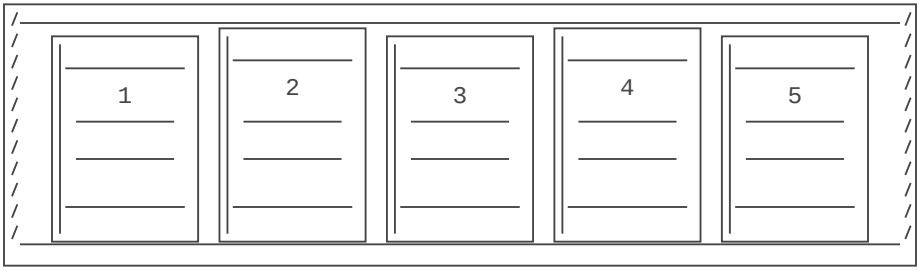
Inventory, unordered: The Weather Atlas · The Quiet Garden · The Dusk Letters · The Hidden River · The Glass Orchard

1. The Glass Orchard is immediately to the left of The Quiet Garden.

2. The Weather Atlas is immediately to the right of The Hidden River.

3. The Quiet Garden is somewhere to the left of The Weather Atlas.

4. The Dusk Letters is somewhere to the left of The Glass Orchard.



Select the book in the middle position.

My discovery:

DOCUMENT III

The private catalogue

Choose the middle book’s card. The printed card order is not the shelf order.

The Hidden River

`WIZDVI`

From the private record

The Glass Orchard

`XSVHG`

From the private record

The Weather Atlas

`OVGGVI`

From the private record

The Dusk Letters

`YLLPH`

From the private record

The Quiet Garden

`XOLXP`

From the private record

Elsie’s rule: pair the alphabet’s first letter with its last, its second with its second-last, and so on. Replace each letter with its partner. The decoded object has a drawer in its wooden base.

My discovery:

DOCUMENT IV

The keeper’s work log

Inside the wooden base, a label refers to this log. The drawer has four combination wheels.

BELLWETHER ARCHIVE

I began at 09:45. Each task followed the last,

in order, with no overlaps or other breaks.

I set the combination to my finishing time.

Polish the archive plates	22 min
Replace the shelf labels	17 min
Wrap the light-sensitive papers	26 min
Inspect the wooden base	15 min

Use 24-hour form. Remove the colon, keeping both hour digits and both minute digits.